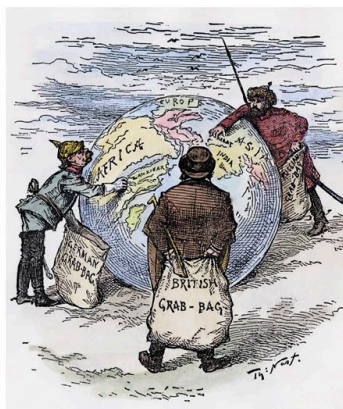




△ **Ravaging their colonies**
Contemporary cartoons frequently satirized the plundering nature of imperialism. In this American cartoon from 1885, Germany, England, and Russia grab pieces of Africa and Asia.

THE AGE OF IMPERIALISM

In the 19th century, forces of imperialism reshaped the world, as nations sought to gain control of overseas territories that would provide valuable resources, space for growing populations, and power in a competitive world.

The middle of the 19th century witnessed a dramatic shift in European overseas expansion. For centuries, European activities overseas had been dominated by trade and the creation of a chain of staging posts, by which the riches of the East could be brought to Europe. However, this changed in the 1870s. Countries everywhere scrambled to annex new territories and strengthen their control over existing colonies, and new nations competed with the old colonial powers. By 1900, the world was largely imperial, setting the stage for World War I.

Reasons for imperialism

The shift from colonialism to imperialism was largely driven and facilitated by industrialization (see pp.232–233), which required vast amounts of raw materials. Imperialism gave nations control over raw materials, access to labor and huge new markets, and plenty of investment opportunities.

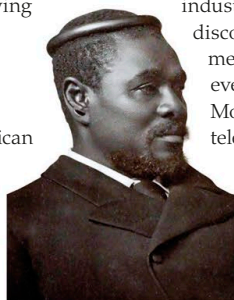
The colonies offered ample chances for those hoping to make their fortune, and some countries—mainly Britain and France—needed space for their growing populations. The desire to become a “Great Power” also nudged many countries to expand. European countries were keen to reassert themselves or carve out new identities. Britain hoped to recover its stature after losing its American colonies, France wanted to rebuild its power, and Russia continued its push eastward into the weakening Qing Empire in China. From the 1860s, the young nations of Germany, Italy, and the US sought to become world powers. Emerging from centuries of

isolation, Japan, too, was keen to gain access to the resources it lacked and living space for its people, while being painfully aware that it was itself vulnerable to imperialism.

In addition to the economic and political benefits of imperialism, there was also a belief in the superiority of the white man. As scientists sought to apply Charles Darwin’s theory of evolution to humankind, the perceived “advanced” state of Western society was used to justify imperialism. Many Westerners felt that they had a moral duty to Christianize “native” cultures. It was an attitude neatly summed up in Kipling’s 1899 poem “The White Man’s Burden,” which exhorted Americans to colonize the Philippines. It spoke of a white man’s moral obligation to rule the nonwhite peoples, or the “other,” and encourage their economic, cultural, and social progress.

Building empires

The huge empires built in the 19th century were largely made possible by the advances brought about by industrialization. Modern medicine, such as the discovery of quinine as a treatment for malaria, meant that Europeans could push farther than ever before into lands rife with tropical disease. Modern communications, such as railways and telegraph lines, allowed large areas to be easily

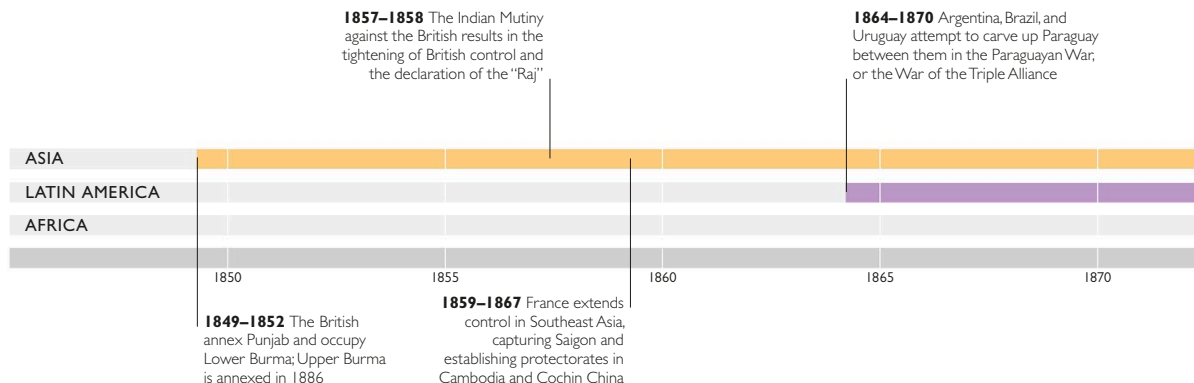


◁ Resisting imperialism

Zulu chief Cetshwayo kaMphande led his warriors against the British in 1879. His defeat removed a major threat to British colonial interests in South Africa.

THE IMPERIAL WORLD

Patterns of imperial activity varied around the world. While the colonization of Africa was marked by a scramble in which almost all major European countries took part, India and Southeast Asia were mainly dominated by the British and French, respectively. The decaying Qing Empire provided easy pickings for Japan and Russia. While Britain and the US sought to bring Latin America within their spheres of influence, Latin American countries also embarked on their own expansionist ventures.





◁ Soft imperialism

Built with British expertise, using British materials, the Retiro Railway Station in Buenos Aires is an example of how imperial influence extended beyond official colonies through cultural, financial, and industrial means.

controlled. New mechanized weaponry made it possible to suppress local resistance; this also meant that brutality was a frequent companion of imperialism.

Even countries that were not directly colonized came under the influence of imperialist nations. For example, in Latin America, political and economic intervention helped secure American and British influence in the region. Cultural influence helped the imperialist nations to embed their lifestyles and aspirations both in their colonies and beyond.

"I am an anti-imperialist. I am opposed to having the eagle put its talons on any other land."

MARK TWAIN, WRITER,
NEW YORK HERALD, 1900

▽ Military might

Japan destroyed Russia's Baltic Fleet at the Battle of Tsushima in 1905 during the Russo-Japanese War. Japan's victory was proof of her increasing military and imperial power and of Russia's growing weakness.



1876 Queen Victoria is proclaimed the Empress of India

1884–1899 Germany creates German New Guinea after annexing territories in the Pacific

1889–1896 Italy establishes its first colony in Eritrea but is kept out of Abyssinia by the armies of King Menelik II at the Battle of Adwa

1895 France creates the federation of French West Africa, comprising eight territories

1895–1898 The Venezuela Crisis—a border dispute between British Guyana and Venezuela—justifies US intervention in the region

1904–1905 Japan defeats Russia to become the first non-European nation to defeat a great European power

1876 A scramble for Africa begins when Belgian King Leopold II begins colonizing Congo

1884–1886 Germany acquires parts of southwest Africa, present-day Togo, and Cameroon. It agrees to share east Africa with Britain

1894–1895 Japan gains control of China's Liaodong peninsula and annexes Formosa (modern-day Taiwan)

1898 Victory in the Spanish-American War gives the US Cuba and Puerto Rico

1899–1902 The Second Anglo-Boer War gives Britain control of South Africa, paving the way for the creation of the British Union of South Africa in 1910

THE NEW IMPERIALISM

The 19th century saw a remarkable wave of imperial activity as freedom from war, the second wave of the Industrial Revolution, and the emergence of new countries fueled the land grab of most of Africa, the Pacific, and southern Asia among European powers.

In 1830, the European colonies were in retreat. The French, British, and Spanish had been swept out of the Americas in a wave of revolution. Only Russia, with its vast empire in north and central Asia, and Britain, holding Canada, Australia, and India, retained significant territory. However, conditions were ripe for the emergence of renewed imperial activity and new forms of imperialism.

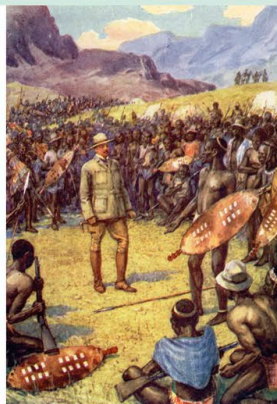
Britain made a cautious start. Many of its acquisitions—Singapore (1819), Malacca (1824), Hong Kong (1842), Natal (1843), and Lower Burma (1852)—were driven by a desire to secure the trade routes to the East Indies and protect its position in India. France acquired Algeria (1830s) and Tahiti and the Marquesas in the South Pacific (1840s), then gained a foothold in Indochina (1858–1859).

By 1870, Europeans had not yet penetrated Africa's interior, and much of Indochina and China remained untouched, but this was not to last far beyond 1880, when the Second Industrial Revolution created a strong demand for raw materials and markets. By then, the unified countries of Germany and Italy—along with the US and Japan—were eager to challenge the older colonial powers. In the last 20 years of the century, the European nations carved up almost all of Africa, while in Asia, the weakness of the Qing Dynasty allowed the French, British, Russians, and Japanese to extend their influence deep into China. Between 1880 and 1914, Europe added 8.5 million square miles (20.7 million sq km) to its overseas possessions, and Britain and France ruled more than 500 million people between them.

OVERCOMING RESISTANCE FORCE AND TRICKERY IN THE COLONIES

Colonists faced almost constant pressure from local uprisings. In Indochina, for example, the French were engaged in a guerilla war from 1883–1913. Brute force was the usual response—the Herero rising against the Germans in Southwest Africa in 1904 ended in genocide—but trickery played a part, too, as Cecil Rhodes showed when in 1888, he deceived King Lobengula into signing away mining rights for his territory in Matabeleland.

Cecil Rhodes with the Matabeles
Rhodes, prime minister of Britain's Cape Colony, confronts the Matabele in this contemporary illustration.

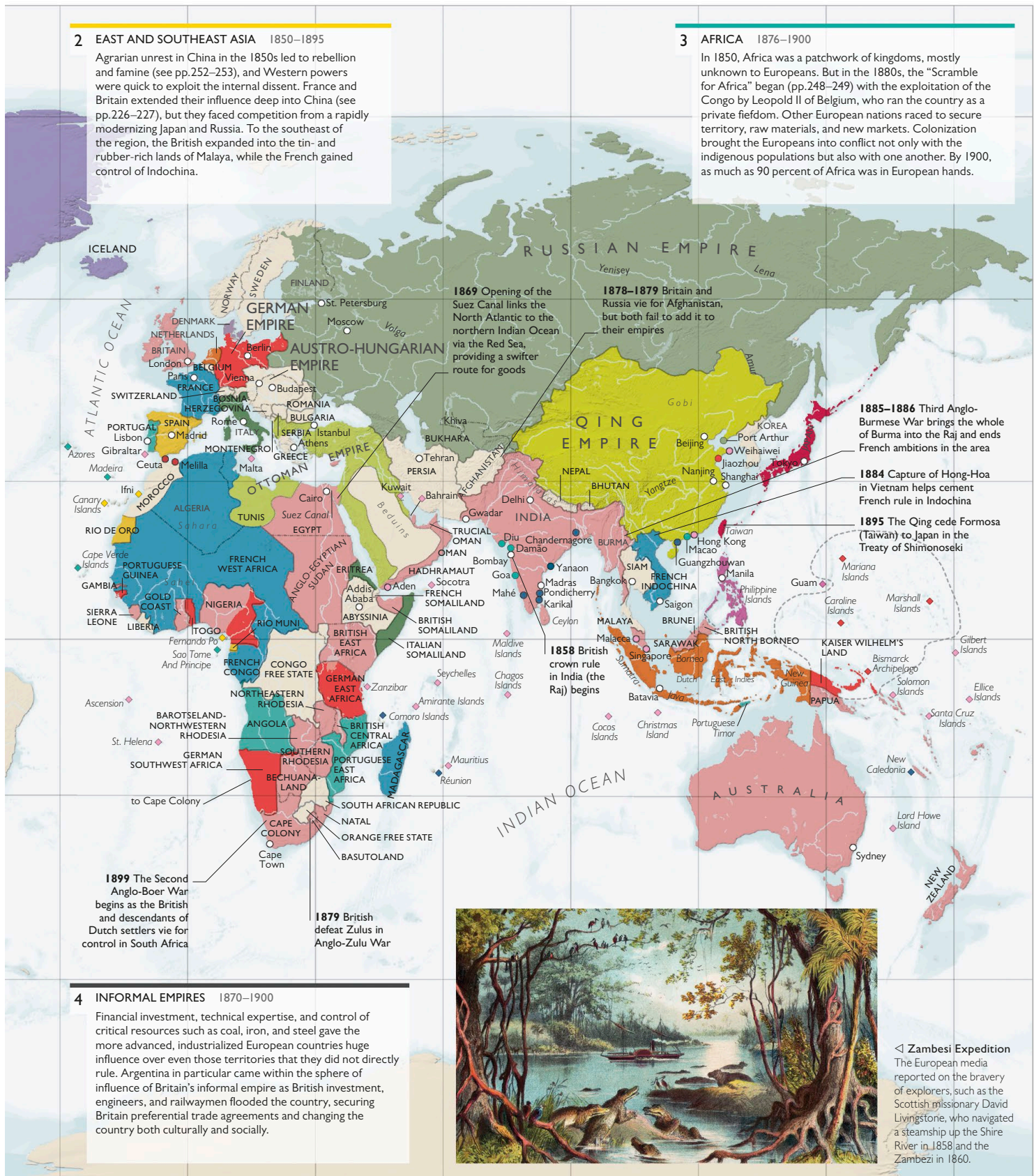


2 EAST AND SOUTHEAST ASIA 1850–1895

Agrarian unrest in China in the 1850s led to rebellion and famine (see pp.252–253), and Western powers were quick to exploit the internal dissent. France and Britain extended their influence deep into China (see pp.226–227), but they faced competition from a rapidly modernizing Japan and Russia. To the southeast of the region, the British expanded into the tin- and rubber-rich lands of Malaya, while the French gained control of Indochina.

3 AFRICA 1876–1900

In 1850, Africa was a patchwork of kingdoms, mostly unknown to Europeans. But in the 1880s, the “Scramble for Africa” began (pp.248–249) with the exploitation of the Congo by Leopold II of Belgium, who ran the country as a private fiefdom. Other European nations raced to secure territory, raw materials, and new markets. Colonization brought the Europeans into conflict not only with the indigenous populations but also with one another. By 1900, as much as 90 percent of Africa was in European hands.



RESISTANCE AND THE RAJ

In 1857–1858, a revolt by Indian soldiers threatened to force the British out of India. Instead, the British increased their control, creating the Raj under the direct rule of Queen Victoria.

Unrest was growing in India in the 1850s. Indians were worried about British expansionism and feared forced conversion to Christianity, suspecting that the British were trying to undermine traditional culture.

In 1857, a rumor spread among the sepoys (native soldiers) employed by the British. They came to believe that cartridges for the new Enfield rifles, which had to be opened with the teeth, were greased with cow or pig fat. This caused offense to both Hindus, who believed cows were sacred, and Muslims, who thought pigs were unclean. In spite of British reassurances that the cartridges were free from animal fat, the sepoys on parade at Meerut on May 10, 1857, refused to use them and mutinied.



△ Enfield rifle cartridges
Rumors about the fat used to grease the new Enfield rifle cartridges sparked a mutiny among India's sepoys, which developed into a wide-reaching Indian Revolt.

The mutiny quickly developed into a general revolt, spreading through Bengal, Oudh, and the Northwest Provinces as local princes, such as Nana Sahib and Lakshmi Bai, the Rani

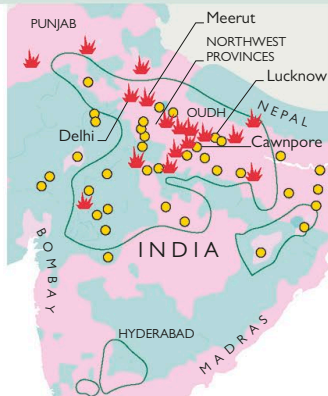
of Jhansi, tried to drive out the British. After atrocities on both sides, the British succeeded in quelling the rebellion by the end of 1858. Their position in India was totally changed. The East India Company was abolished, and the last ruler of the Mughal line, Bahadur Shah Zafar, was tried for treason and exiled, opening the way for direct rule by the British over India. The British Raj had been born.

THE REVOLT OF 1857–1858

From Meerut, the mutiny soon spread to other sepoy regiments around India and to the general populace. Some princely states remained neutral or loyal to the British, while others seized the chance to rebel. The revolt remained largely centered in northern India.

KEY

- British India
- Princely states
- Areas affected by the revolt
- Posts at which Indian troops mutinied
- Main centers of rebellion



The Siege of Lucknow

Part of the British administrative headquarters, or Residency, in Lucknow, the Chattar Manzil palace was besieged by rebel forces for several months. The siege was eventually broken by the British in March 1858.







△ The *Petropavlovsk* sinks
Russia clashed with Japan over rival imperial ambitions in Manchuria and Korea. The battleship *Petropavlovsk*, shown in this illustration, was a casualty of the Russo-Japanese War in 1904.

1854–1855 The Siege of Sevastopol ends Russia's attempt to expand its territories in the Black Sea region

1 THE CONQUEST OF SIBERIA 1600–1812

Russia first tried to find a sea passage from the Arctic to the Pacific Ocean. When this failed, it turned to conquering Siberia in order to gain access to the Pacific coast and to win control over its land, minerals, and fur trade. Military forays and massacres, as well as diseases brought in by Russian trappers and traders, subdued the indigenous peoples. By 1650, Russia had colonized the whole of north Asia. Russia then reached North America, where it founded colonies in Alaska (1784) and California (1812).

2 EXPANSION TO THE WEST 1768–1815

For centuries, the Swedish Empire and the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth had limited Russia's western territory. However, the military reforms of two czars, Ivan V and Peter the Great, helped to bring much of Poland and Lithuania into the empire by 1795. Success against Sweden in the Finnish War (1808–1809) gave Russia the Grand Duchy of Finland. A final shuffle of Polish territories after the Napoleonic Wars (1803–1815) defined the western limits of the Russian Empire.

3 THE BLACK SEA AND CRIMEA 1768–1856

Under Empress Catherine the Great, Russia moved toward the Black Sea, securing the independence of the Crimean Khanate from the Ottoman Empire in the Russo-Turkish War (1768–1774) and then annexing it in 1783. By 1815, Russia had gained control of the entire northern shore of the Black Sea, and finally it had a warm-water port. Russia's attempt to occupy the Balkans, however, was swiftly suppressed in the Crimean War (1853–1856).

🚢 New Russian port

4 CENTRAL ASIA AND "THE GREAT GAME" 1830–1895

As Russia moved south and Britain moved north from its power base in India, a series of political and diplomatic confrontations known as "The Great Game" played out, as each side tried to expand its influence in Afghanistan and its surrounding countries. Ultimately, Afghanistan became a buffer zone, but Russia was able to annex the valuable lands of Bukhara, Khiva, and Samarkand.

🚩 Acquired by Russia during "The Great Game" 🇦🇫 Afghanistan

5 RUSSIA AND MANCHURIA 1858–1914

From 1858, a weakening Qing Empire ceded Outer Manchuria to Russia—an area from which it had previously been excluded by the Treaty of Nerchinsk (1689). Russia founded Vladivostok, a relatively ice-free port and, in 1898, leased the Liaodong Peninsula from China, gaining the warm-water port of Port Arthur. Alarmed by Japan's growing interest in China, Russia occupied southern Manchuria but was defeated in the Russo-Japanese War (1904–1905) and abandoned its imperial ambitions in the area.

🚢 New Russian port





RUSSIAN EMPIRE EXPANDS

From 1600, Russia set out on a mission to expand its territory. It conquered Siberia, reached North America, drove deep into central Asia, and gained a foothold in the Black Sea region. By the 19th century, Russia's sizeable empire had begun to alarm Europe.

In 1600, the Czarism of Russia spread from the Ural Mountains in the east to the edge of the great Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth in the west. It was, however, effectively landlocked; the Arctic Ocean was often frozen, and the Baltic Sea was controlled by Russia's enemy, Sweden. Consequently, Russia's expansion over the next 400 years was driven, to a great extent, by the search for a warm-water port that would allow it to house a fleet to rival the French and British navies and that would provide access to international trade.

Russia seized Siberia by conquest, but the growth of the empire was largely achieved by a process of accretion. Territories occupied by Russian migrants were slowly incorporated into the empire, and as the older powers—such as the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth, the Ottoman Empire in central Asia, and the Qing Empire in China—weakened, Russia simply took over. Russia's attempts at more aggressive expansion in the Balkans, Manchuria, and to the north of Afghanistan met with varying degrees of success, and, in the end, the limits of Russia's empire were defined by other imperial powers.

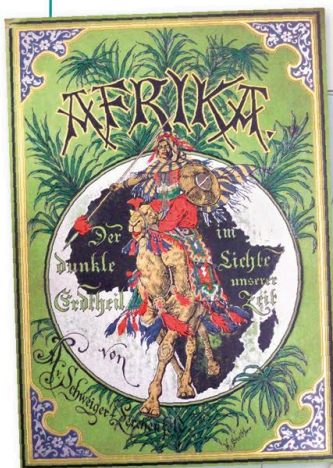
"Russia has only two allies: her army and her fleet."

ALEXANDER III, EMPEROR OF RUSSIA, c.1890

IVAN IV VASILYEVICH 1530–1584

The Grand Prince of Moscow from 1533–1547, Ivan IV Vasilyevich (also known as "the Terrible") became the first czar of Russia in 1547. A brutal autocrat, his rule is considered to mark the beginning of the Russian Empire, as he set about bringing Russia's aristocracy under his autocratic rule and uniting their lands under a central administration. By the time of his death in 1584, Ivan had not only united Russia's princedoms but also conquered Kazan, Astrakhan, and parts of Siberia, setting the foundation for a vast empire that would span much of Europe and Asia.





A view from Europe
The cover of this German book, published in 1886 (*Africa: The Dark Earth in the Light of our Time*), presents a highly romanticized view of African colonization to its European readers.

THE GAMBIA
PORTUGUESE GUINEA
ATLANTIC OCEAN
SIERRA LEONE
1847 Resettled slaves from America declare Liberia an independent republic

5 RESISTANCE TO COLONIZATION 1896
European colonizers often met with resistance, most of which was brutally suppressed. Yet in Abyssinia, Emperor Menelik II was able to play the Europeans off against each other and secure modern weapons that allowed him to crush an Italian invasion at the Battle of Adowa in 1896 and keep Abyssinia independent of European control.

✗ Battle of Adowa

THE SCRAMBLE FOR AFRICA

Europe's colonial settlements were at first centered on coastal Africa, but from 1880, colonists pushed inward, creating new settlements (dates of establishment in bold type) and frequently competing for territory with one another.

KEY

TERRITORIES c.1880

African peoples and powers
British
French
Ottoman Empire
Portuguese
Spanish

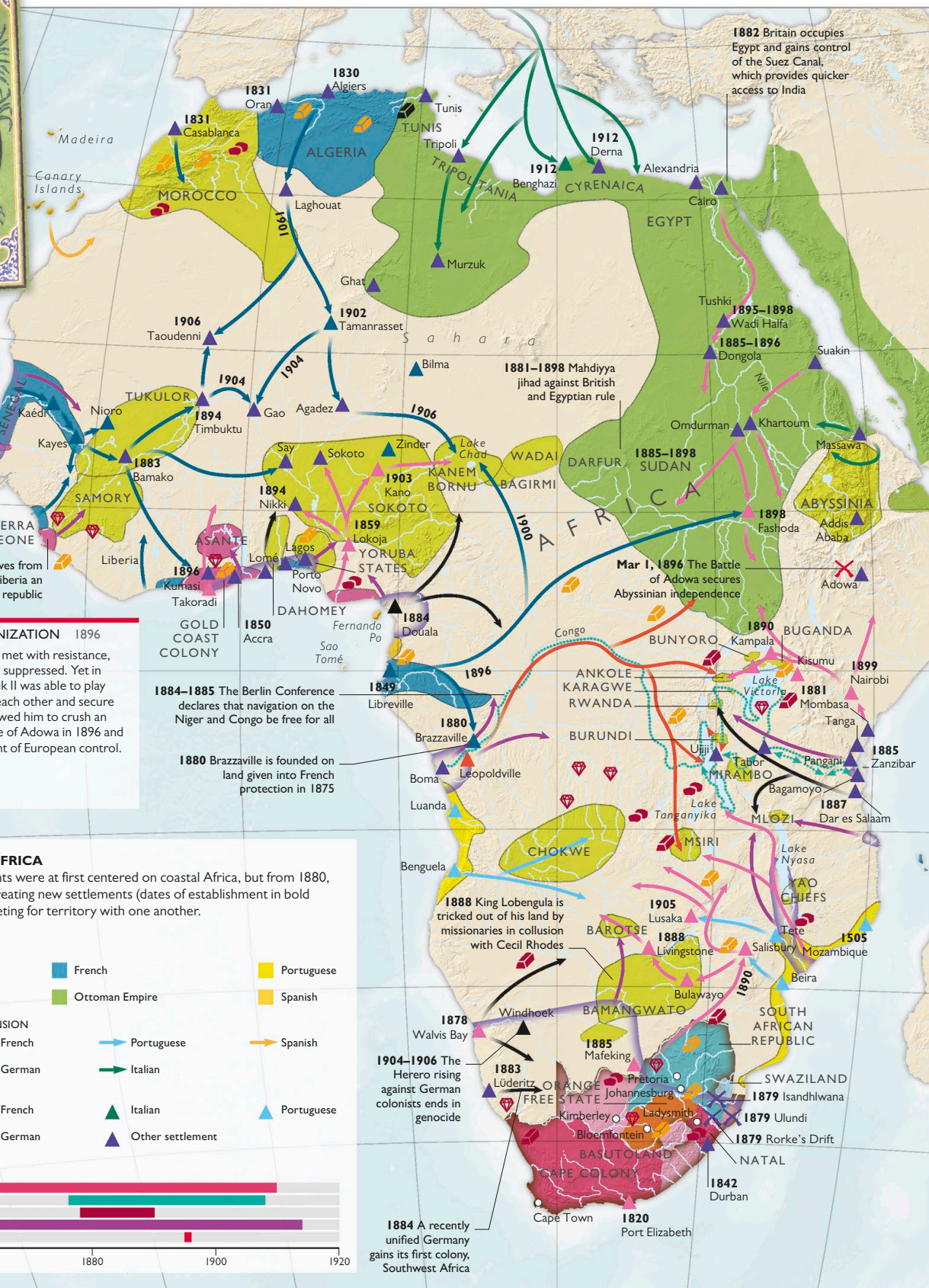
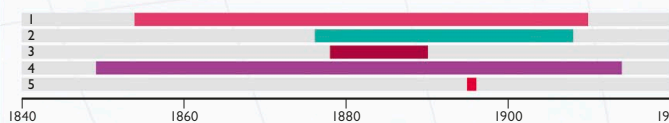
EUROPEAN ROUTES OF EXPANSION

Belgian
British
French
German
Italian
Portuguese
Spanish

COLONIAL SETTLEMENTS

Belgian
British
French
German
Italian
Other settlement
Portuguese

TIMELINE



4 THE ROLE OF MISSIONARIES 1849–1914

In 1849, Scottish missionary David Livingstone headed for Africa. His expeditions made him a hero, and his assertion that slavery in Africa could only be ended through "Christianity, Commerce, and Civilization" sparked a wave of missionary activity. Some provided valuable health and education services, but others colluded with the companies to defraud local chiefs of their lands.

— Frontier of Christian missionary activities c. 1880
— Main lines of missionary advance

3 THE CALL OF COMMERCE 1878–1890

Africa was commercially attractive because it was a huge market for European manufactured goods; it had vast reserves of raw materials—including coal, metal ores, rubber, gold, and diamonds; and it had plentiful labor to raise cash crops. Many early conquests were funded by commercial interests, such as Cecil Rhodes' de Beers Consolidated Mines company (formed in 1888).

IMPORTANT MINERAL DEPOSITS

— Coal — Diamonds
— Copper — Gold

2 LEOPOLD II AND THE CONGO 1876–1908

The scramble for Africa began with King Leopold II of Belgium. In 1876, he created the International African Association—a front for his imperial ambitions. He drew the explorer Henry Stanley (who had spent years exploring the Congo basin) into a secret scheme to carve out a Belgian state in the region. By 1885, Stanley had secured for Leopold the Congo Free State (1885–1908).

— Stanley's route across Africa 1871–1877

1 THE STRUGGLE FOR SOUTH AFRICA 1854–1910

In the 19th century, the Boers, British, and Zulus fought for control of South Africa. Since 1852, the Boers (descendants of the first European settlers) had lived independently in the Orange Free State and Transvaal, while British power was concentrated in Cape Colony and Natal. In 1877, the British annexed Transvaal after gold was found there. At the same time, they decisively crushed the Zulu kingdom. In 1910, after two Anglo-Boer wars (1880–1881, 1899–1902), Transvaal (by then, the South African Republic), the Orange Free State, and the Zulu lands were subsumed by a new British dominion—the Union of South Africa.

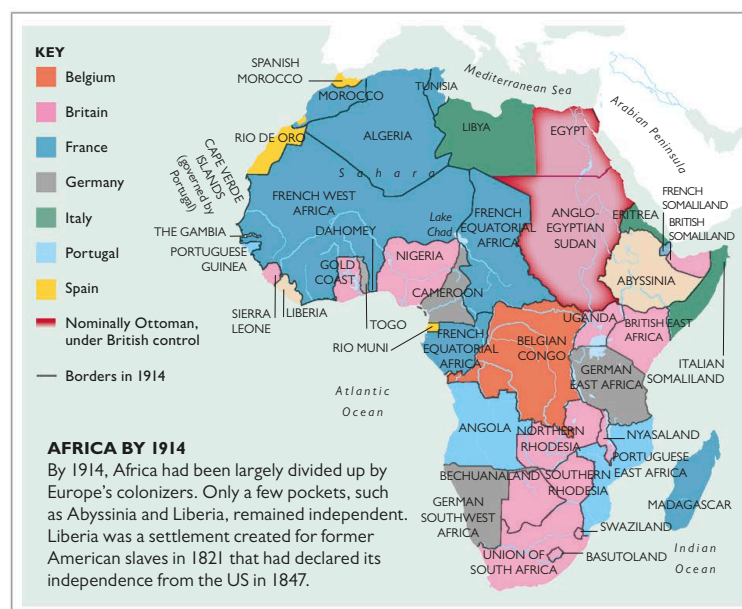
— Cape Colony and Natal 1854
— Territory under British control 1895
— South African Republic 1895
— Orange Free State 1895
— Battle in Zulu wars
— Union of South Africa boundary 1910

AFRICA COLONIZED

In 1880, only a few European colonies dotted the African coastline. Much of the north was formally part of the Ottoman Empire, but most of Africa was free of direct control from outside. By 1914, nine-tenths of the continent had been divided between seven nations, each hungry for resources and keen to build their empires.

The shifting balance of power in Europe in the 19th century was to have lasting consequences for Africa, as nationalist, liberal, and commercial interests converged in an orgy of colonization. Having lost their American colonies, Spain and Portugal also lost influence in Africa, but Britain and France were ready to build their empires after the Napoleonic wars, and the newly unified nations of Italy and Germany sought to bolster their international standing. Tales from African explorers about diamonds, gold, copper, and coal stirred Europe's commercial interest, so when news reached Europe in the 1880s that the Belgian king, Leopold II, had made a grab for the Congo, the race to conquer Africa's interior began.

Competition between the colonizers nearly resulted in conflict, so the Berlin Conference (1884–1885) was called to settle claims and set rules for partition. Missionaries, companies, and military forces all played a part in the colonization process, but it was also made possible by technological and scientific advances that came out of the Industrial Revolution. Steamships—and the discovery of effective antimalarial treatments—allowed Europeans to navigate deep into the continent's interior. The weapons of local peoples were no match for the breech-loading rifle, and within 20 years, Africa had been carved up by European powers with little regard for the traditions of the indigenous peoples.



FOREIGN POWERS IN CHINA

By the mid-19th century, the Qing Empire in China was facing internal strife, as well as pressure from foreign powers. Anger against growing foreign dominance erupted in the Boxer Rebellion, but it was swiftly repressed by a coalition of foreign forces. The subsequent war reparations crippled the empire.

Two hundred years of Qing rule had created a vast empire that flourished economically. Foreign traders were granted access to only one port, Canton (modern Guangzhou), but requests for further concessions were rebuffed.

Western merchants began to bribe officials and pay for goods with opium, which damaged the Chinese economy and led to a rise in opium addiction. The First Opium War (see pp.226–227) resulted in the transfer of Hong Kong and other ports to Britain, and over the next decades, parts of the empire fell under the influence of Britain, France, Russia, Germany, Japan, and the US.

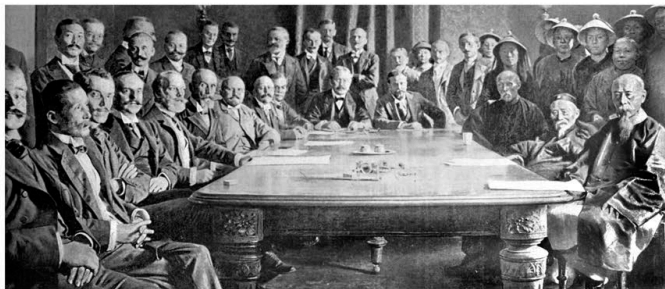
The Boxer Rebellion

By 1900, anger at foreign control of trade and at Christian missionary activity made many Chinese join a secret group known as the Society of Righteous and Harmonious Fists. Popularly called “Boxers,” its members began attacking Westerners and Chinese Christians.

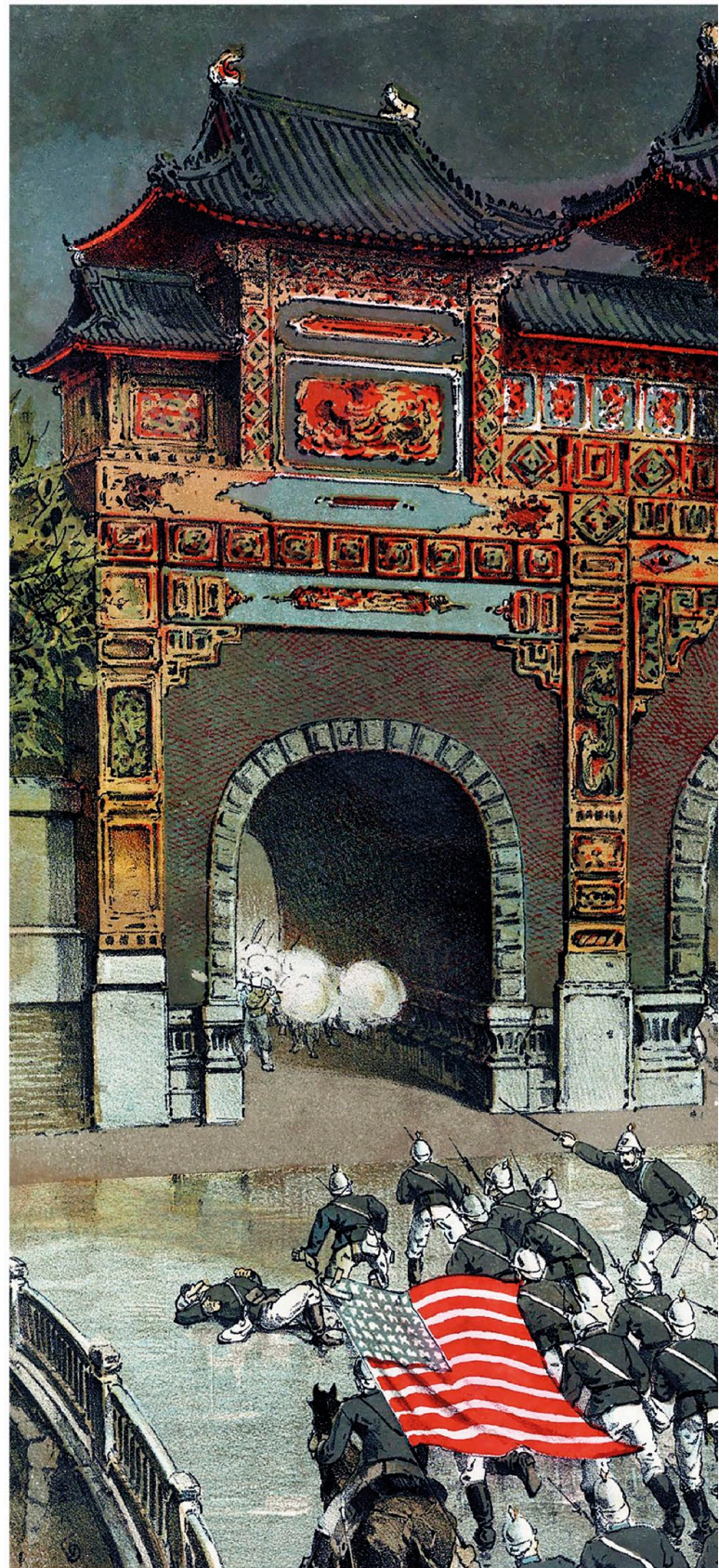
In June 1900, Qing forces and the Boxers besieged the foreign legations in Peking (Beijing). Soldiers from an eight-nation alliance lifted the siege 55 days later, and then demanded war reparations. Damaged by its failure to expel the foreigners and by internal rebellions, the Qing Dynasty could not prevent further losses to foreign powers or stop the spread of revolutionary ideas. In 1912, the last emperor abdicated and China became a republic.



△ **Assassination of Baron Ketteler**
In revenge for his having beaten and shot a boy suspected of being a Boxer, German diplomat Baron Clemens von Ketteler was murdered in Beijing on June 20, 1900. His assassin was later beheaded.



△ **The Peking Protocol**
Having defeated the Boxers, the foreign powers demanded in the Peking Protocol (1901) that China punish the government officials involved in the uprising, pay reparations equivalent to \$330 million, and allow foreign troops to be stationed there.



**Storming the Imperial Palace**

On August 14, 1900, a multinational force, including British, American, and Japanese soldiers, broke the siege of the Imperial Palace in Peking (modern Beijing) by Qing forces and Boxer rebels.

DECLINE OF QING CHINA

The richest and most populous state in the world, Qing China should have been a major presence on the world stage competing with Western powers. Instead, however, it underwent a long decline from the mid-1800s, racked with rebellions and civil wars and repeatedly carved up by foreign military adventures.

The Qing Dynasty was founded by a clan of Manchurians who had seized the Chinese empire and, under a series of forceful emperors (see pp.178–179), enlarged it with conquests in central Asia. But their failure to modernize had exacerbated a series of problems that afflicted China in the 19th century, including population growth and the constant threat of famine; problems with the money supply; failure to open the economy to foreign trade; and failure to keep pace with the technology and military power of foreign states that wanted to impose trade liberalization, and possibly even carve up China between themselves (see pp.250–251).

The humiliations inflicted as a result of the Opium Wars (see pp.226–227) had severely damaged the authority of the Qing and centralized government. In the resulting power vacuum, there flourished corruption, smuggling, and “secret societies”—networks of local leaders and low-ranking nobility with diverse cultural, political, and economic agendas. The threat of rebellion was relentless, and the ground was fertile for mass movements to galvanize resistance to the Qing. This feverish atmosphere would spark the greatest civil war in history and eventually bring to an end the Qing Dynasty and millennia of imperial rule.

“Heaven sees as the people see; Heaven hears as the people hear ... China is weak, the only thing we can depend on is the hearts of the people.”

DOWAGER EMPRESS CIXI DURING THE BOXER REBELLION, 1899–1901

PUYI

1906–1967

The turbulent life of the last Emperor of China traced the history of 20th-century China. Puyi became emperor in 1908, aged only 2, but was forced to abdicate in 1912 as a result of the Xinhai revolution. He was briefly restored as puppet emperor by a warlord in 1917 and again by the Japanese in 1934. Later, he was captured by the Soviets, then handed over to the Chinese Communists after World War II and reeducated to be a common citizen. He died in Beijing in 1967.

Emperor Puyi as a child
Puyi (seen here aged 3) was proclaimed the Xuantong Emperor by his great-aunt, the Dowager Empress Cixi.



△ Imperial troops march against the Taiping

A contemporary image of imperial troops marching to battle against the Taiping rebels. The civil war set off by the rebellion was one of the largest conflicts the world had ever seen.

1 OUTBREAK OF THE TAIPIING REBELLION 1844–1853

Hong Xiuquan was a quasi-Christian visionary around whom a cult grew in Guangxi province in the 1840s. In 1851, Hong proclaimed a new dynasty, the Taiping Tianguo (“Heavenly Kingdom of Great Peace”), and assumed the title of Tianwang, or “Heavenly King.” Shrugging off imperial assaults, his rebellion gathered strength and made Nanjing its capital.

→ Hong’s march to Nanjing 1850–1853

2 THE TAIPIING EMPIRE 1853–1860

The Taiping Empire presented a challenge to the Qing, but infighting and failed military expeditions checked its momentum. In 1856, feuding between the Taiping’s top military leaders saw two of them murdered and a third flee with many men. An 1860 attempt to take Shanghai was stopped by the “Ever-Victorious Army.” Western-trained and led troops fighting for the Qing.

Area controlled by rebels c.1861 Unsuccessful northern campaign 1853–1855

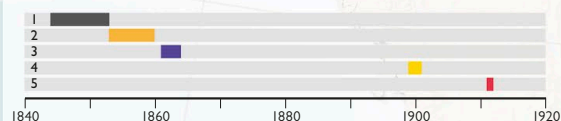
THE END OF IMPERIAL RULE

The power of the Qing Dynasty started to decline significantly from the 1840s, and a series of uprisings finally ended their rule in 1911–1912.

KEY

Qing Empire 1850

TIMELINE



JAPAN TRANSFORMED

The restoration of the Meiji (“enlightened rule”) emperor in 1868 kick-started a process of modernization that would see Japan transformed from an isolationist, feudal country to an outward-looking industrial nation with an educated population and an army and navy ready to defend and strengthen its position in the world.

By 1850, Japan had endured 200 years of isolation under the Tokugawa shogunate (see pp.180–181). The country was weak compared to foreign powers and was forced to accept unfavorable treaties that undermined its sovereignty.

An alliance of samurai from Japan’s western domains began to coalesce around the imperial court in Kyoto, and by 1868 sought to restore imperial power and to modernize Japan. The shogun, Tokugawa Yoshinobu, resigned in an attempt to maintain peace but could not prevent the clash between imperial and government forces in the Boshin War of 1868–1869. The imperial faction won the conflict, securing the emperor’s position, although not his personal

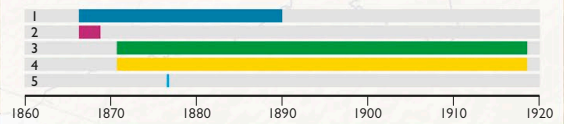
power. A group of ambitious young samurai took control of the country and soon began to implement profound reform. They asked the feudal lords to give up their domains in favor of a centralized state, placed the nation’s defense in the hands of a new imperial army and navy, and promoted rapid industrialization to transform Japan’s economic base.

It was little wonder that many of the older samurai from the most powerful clans balked at the changes and rebelled in 1877. The rebellion (known after its origin in Satsuma Domain) failed, but it forced a reassessment of reform, ensuring that Japanese values were not lost in the race to modernize.

MODERNIZATION OF JAPAN

The modernization of Japan progressed swiftly between 1868 and 1918, as the new government swept away feudal structures and established power bases during the Boshin War and Satsuma Rebellion, paving the way for rapidly developing industrial areas and increasing urbanization.

TIMELINE



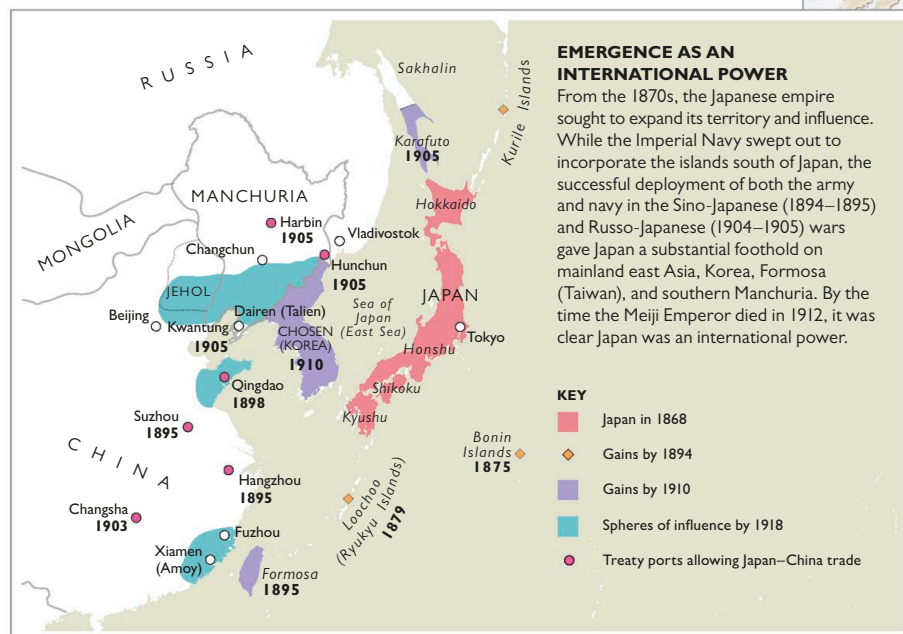
2 BOSHIN WAR 1868–1869

Civil war broke out between imperial forces and troops loyal to the ex-shogun, Tokugawa Yoshinobu, when Yoshinobu was stripped of all titles and land. The imperial troops won the war’s first battle, at Fushimi on January 27, 1868. They then moved east to secure Edo’s surrender, before heading north to Hokkaido to defeat the remaining government supporters at Hakodate in June 1869.

→ Route of imperial army ✕ Battle, with date
■ Imperial alliance

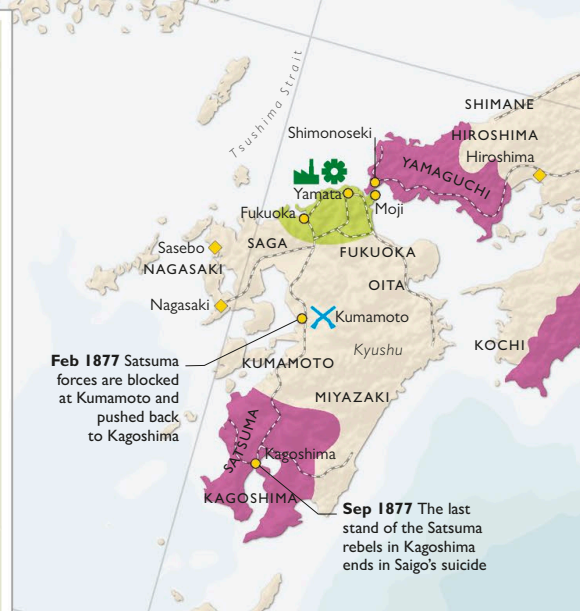
1 MODERNIZATION OF THE ARMY AND NAVY 1868–1890

The Meiji government’s determination to modernize the military cut across the privileges of Japan’s warrior class, the samurai. In 1869, their fleets were subsumed by the new Imperial Japanese Navy, and in 1873, their exclusive right to bear arms was broken by the introduction of conscription. Many samurai became officers in the new regime, where their discipline helped to create the most powerful military force in Asia by the 1890s.



EMERGENCE AS AN INTERNATIONAL POWER

From the 1870s, the Japanese empire sought to expand its territory and influence. While the Imperial Navy swept out to incorporate the islands south of Japan, the successful deployment of both the army and navy in the Sino-Japanese (1894–1895) and Russo-Japanese (1904–1905) wars gave Japan a substantial foothold on mainland east Asia, Korea, Formosa (Taiwan), and southern Manchuria. By the time the Meiji Emperor died in 1912, it was clear Japan was an international power.



3 INDUSTRIALIZATION 1871–1918

The abolition of feudalism in Japan freed millions of people to choose their occupation and move around the country. The government encouraged industrialization, building railway and shipping lines and telegraph and telephone systems, as well as opening mines; shipyards; and munitions, glass, textile, and chemical factories. Many of these were privatized when a European-style banking system was introduced in 1882, leaving the government free to invest in education and the armed forces.

MODERNIZATION UNDER THE MEIJI

■ Main industrial areas by 1918

▬ Railways built 1868–1918

TRADITIONAL INDUSTRIES

🏺 Ceramics 🧶 Textiles 🐛 Silk

INDUSTRIES DEVELOPED AFTER 1868

🏭 Manufacturing 🚢 Shipbuilding
⚙️ Machine-building 🧪 Chemicals

4 URBAN GROWTH 1871–1918

By 1871, all of Japan's ancient feudal domains, loyal to the local lord, had been reorganized into prefectures, each with a chief executive answerable to the central government. Initially, Japan's urban prefectures—Tokyo, Osaka, and Kyoto—lost population as people adjusted to the new regime and migrated to other areas. However, by 1883, the work offered through industrialization was driving population growth in the urban prefectures and in emerging cities such as Kobe, Yokohama, Nagasaki, and Hiroshima.

◆ City of over 500,000 in 1918
■ City of over 100,000 in 1918

● Other major city

1871 Akita is one of the prefectures—the divisions of the new centralized state created when the feudal domains are abolished

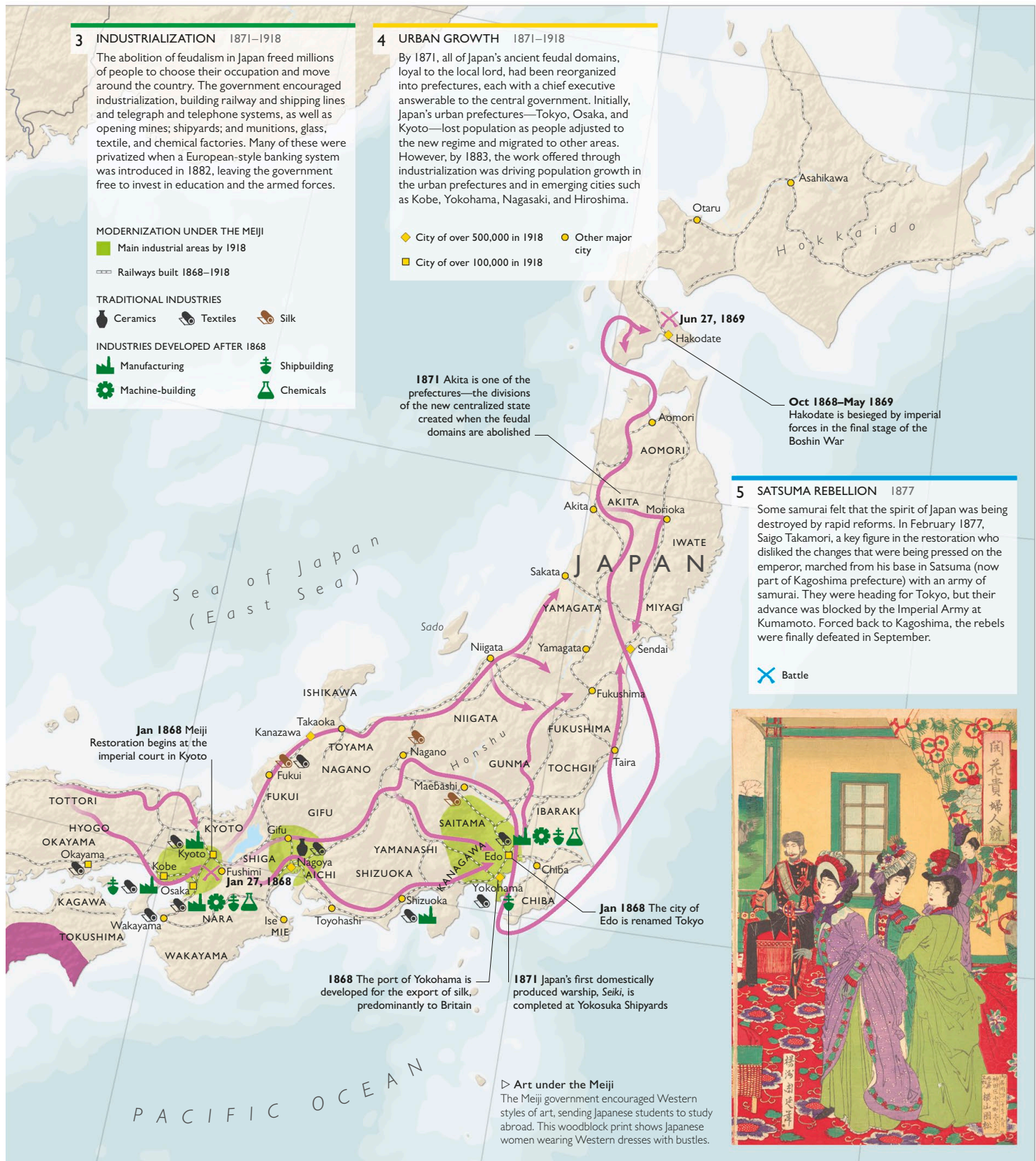
Jun 27, 1869
Hakodate

Oct 1868–May 1869
Hakodate is besieged by imperial forces in the final stage of the Boshin War

5 SATSUMA REBELLION 1877

Some samurai felt that the spirit of Japan was being destroyed by rapid reforms. In February 1877, Saigō Takamori, a key figure in the restoration who disliked the changes that were being pressed on the emperor, marched from his base in Satsuma (now part of Kagoshima prefecture) with an army of samurai. They were heading for Tokyo, but their advance was blocked by the Imperial Army at Kumamoto. Forced back to Kagoshima, the rebels were finally defeated in September.

✕ Battle



▷ Art under the Meiji

The Meiji government encouraged Western styles of art, sending Japanese students to study abroad. This woodblock print shows Japanese women wearing Western dresses with bustles.

